the OC conducted a "biased probe", alleging that in-camera proceedings were not held properly and the cameras were switched off repeatedly while their statements were being recorded. "We are trying to make our case strong and foolproof with all available pieces of evidence before filing a chargesheet," a police officer said on condition of anonymity.

Many activists, however, are horrified at the way the victims have been treated. In a bizarre attempt to recreate the crime scene, one wrestler was taken to Singh's house/WFI office while he was allegedly on the premises. "It is a mockery of the law," says feminist activist Kavita Krishnan. "No victim should have to be taken to the crime scene and forced to re-enact trauma just to show the police are doing their job." The police have also asked for video and photographic proof of the assault. "Do they think assault is done openly and without keeping in mind chances of being caught?" asks Krishnan. "And that victims carry around recorders?"

DANGAL FOR A CAUSE

Sexual harassment is deeply entrenched in sports across the world, with innumerable cases of those in power abusing athletes. In the United States, over 200 female gymnasts, including Olympic gold medalist Simone Biles, shared their testimonies to ensure Larry Nassar, the doctor on the US women's team, was put behind bars for life for nearly two decades of sexual harassment. Nassar would assault the athletes, many of them minors, on the pretext of giving them medical treatment. South Korean short track speed skating was rocked by a charge of sexual assault that led to a coach being found guilty of rape. More recently, 50 current and former fencers in Canada called for a judicial inquiry against their federation for two decades of "emotional, physical and sexual abuse and misconduct".

India's own track record in handling sexual harassment allegations has been less than inspiring. In 2020, the Sports Authority of India, in response to an RTI request by news daily *Indian Express,* disclosed that in the past decade, there were 45 complaints of sexual harassment across 24 government-run centres, 29 of them implicating coaches. While investigations in some cases dragged on, the punishment at best was a transfer to another facility or a cut in pension or pay. The fact that many of the sports federations are headed by politicians, some of whom believe that their political connections will allow them to get away with anything, also perpetuates a climate of impunity. More than half of India's sports federations are headed by politicians or their kin (see *Sports and Politics*). Says a leading sports administrator who has worked with Olympians, "If India ever wants to become a sporting nation, it has to [get] past political appointments and favouritism to get people in charge who actually know the sport, run it very clinically and run it for the interest of the sport." Which makes the protest of the women wrestlers crucial for Indian sports. Arjuna Award-winning swimmer Nisha Millet, who now runs an academy in Bengaluru, says it only highlights the dire need for more women in sports in different capacities—in administrative, managerial or coaching roles. "We need more women in federations to battle stigma and for empathy," she says. Millet is also disappointed by the meagre support that their peers have extended to the wrestlers. Barring the 1983 World Cup-winning cricket team (but not BCCI president Roger Binny) and a few supportive tweets from Abhinav Bindra, Sunil Chhetri, Neeraj Chopra and Nikhat Zareen among others, there has been silence from most athletes. IOA president and former sprinter P.T. Usha attracted criticism for labelling the wrestlers' actions as "gross indiscipline". When Babita Phogat told INDIA TODAY that the wrestlers were being misguided and manipulated by the Opposition after they were arrested and decided to immerse their medals, Vinesh addressed her cousin in a tweet: "If you cannot stand for the rights of aggrieved female wrestlers, then, Babita *behen*, I urge you with folded hands not to weaken our movement.... You are also a woman, try to understand our pain."

That many sports federations are headed by politicians, some of whom believe their connections will allow them get away with anything, perpetuates the climate of impunity

As things stand, Vinesh and Punia are paying the heaviest price. The two are India's best in their weight categories—53 and 65 kg, respectively. Instead of training for upcoming events, including the 2024 Paris Games, they are having to camp in the open, visit the police station and the homes of Union ministers for hours-long negotiations. With WFI in limbo, ultimately the sport will suffer.

In an uplifting climax in *Dangal*, the film that made almost Rs 2,000 crore at box-offices worldwide, Babita Phogat celebrates her victory with the national anthem reverberating in the stadium. It inspired many young girls to head to the nearest akhara to fulfil their own dreams of doing the nation proud. And though Babita today may seem to be on the other side of the struggle, her sisters are continuing the fight for the sorority and sports itself. "We are doing this to improve conditions for girls in sports," says Malik, "so that they can feel safe." The ending of this dangal will matter too. It will determine whether young girls will join sports in larger numbers or consign their hopes to a free-flowing river. ■

—with Pradip R. Sagar and Prashant Srivastava